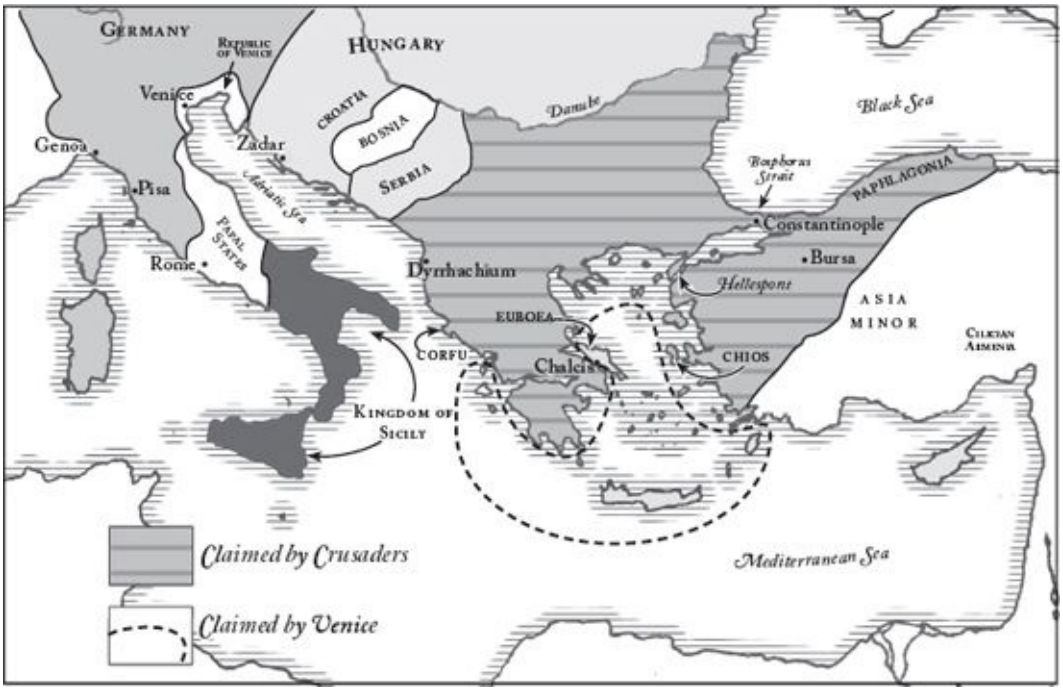
from looting Constantinople's luxurious wine cellars. They were, says Nicetas Choniates, braying like salacious asses at the very sight of women, and a sickness of rape swept through the city. No one was spared: virgins, married women, the old, even nuns were violated in the streets. Men who tried to stop the assaults were run through, decapitated, or left to die in the streets with their limbs hacked off. Nicetas himself managed to get his pregnant wife out of the city by smearing her face with mud and shielding her with his own body.[12]

Finally, when the looting and murder had run its course, Crusaders elected one of their own, the Count of Flanders, to be the new emperor: Emperor Baldwin I. Constantinople had been transformed into the capital of yet another Crusader kingdom: the Latin Empire.

And that was the end of the Crusade. Not a single Crusader made it to Egypt, let alone Jerusalem.

Innocent III, appalled at the bloody ending to his treasured cause, sent a fierce reproof from Rome: "They who are supposed to serve Christ rather than themselves," he wrote, ". . . have bathed those swords in the blood of Christians."[13]



25.1 The Conquest of Constantinople

But self-service had been a part of the crusading impulse since Bohemund's refusal to give up Antioch. The rot that had set in after the First Crusade had eaten through to the surface; when a crusade offered power, the